



KOLKATA'S COFFEE HOUSE (ABOVE);
MAMATA BANERJEE AT A RALLY
IN SINGUR (RIGHT)

away from the Left. People like Mahasweta Devi—Magsaysay Award winner, writer of the epochal *Hazar Churasir Ma* and an avowed leftist all her life—now share Banerjee's dais. "The Left has ceased to exist. How can I support those who grab land in the name of development? How can I call them leftists? The character has changed. The Left by definition is pro-people; now it has become pro-rich," she says.

Intellectuals like Mrinal Sen, Ritwick Ghatak, Utpal Dutt, Bratya Basu, Kaushik Sen, Shaonli Mitra, Rituparno Ghosh and Shuvaprasanna—who had never made any political noises—are today looked upon as deserters given the age-old definition that a Bengali intellectual had to be a leftist first and an artist later. They are now against the same Left Front Government which rode to power 32 years ago on the high of a Bengali intellectual support base. What is left of that base is a few ex-Naxals, some editors with a falling circulation of their newspapers and teachers who have their fingers in every profit pie.

The change is visible. Young Trinamool Congress leaders are flourishing, mouthing words which made the Left leaders in their prime the darlings of the masses. Subhendu

Adhikari, a first-time Trinamool MP, is a prime example. Working from the Tamruk region, home to Nandigram and Singur, he is a man who breathes fire but lets out no venom. Son of Union Minister Shishir Adhikari, Subhendu's well-oiled administration machinery saw his brother, the raw Dibyendu, win the last Assembly bypolls. Almost a throwback to the Left in the early '80s when the machinery was greater than the individual.

On the other hand, Left Front minister Sushanta Ghosh behaves like a lumpen and talks of raising a Left cadre army with weapons to fight the Maoists. Both Subhendu and Ghosh belong to Nandigram-Singur, a region affected by Maoists. Their words vary so much that the distinctions of party colours get blurred, leaving one guessing who the real leftist is. Enter the neo-

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APARNA SEN, filmmaker



leftist, like Subhendu, filling in the gap and the story is complete.

Educationist Abhijit Gupta, a man who saw the Bengali leftist flower during the '70s and early '80s, says, "The demise of the bearded, Neruda-reading *jholawallahs* reflects the changes that have taken place following economic liberalisation. The *jhola* as an accessory now has to compete with the likes of i-Pods, camera phones and backpacks." But economist Abhirup Sarkar believes that leftism has not left Bengal. "There has only been a locational shift. The *jholawallah* has just been pushed to the suburbs from the Coffee House in Kolkata."

However, the very fact that all necessary accessories of being Left have disappeared from the city is proof enough that the opinion-maker in Bengal is not a leftist any longer. From the '60s to the '80s, everything in Kolkata was Left, though the urban votes, more often than not, went to the Congress. However, this takes nothing away from leftism as not only a political theory. Bengal has worshipped Indira Gandhi as "Asia's Mukti Surya", which used to be on posters and